

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 8

By Clemmons

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of James Ralph Sasser.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of James Ralph Sasser, former United States Senator for the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Senator Jim Sasser was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, born in Memphis in 1936, James Ralph Sasser attended the University of Tennessee and graduated from Vanderbilt University in 1958 before receiving his law degree from Vanderbilt University Law School in 1961; and

WHEREAS, Senator Sasser began his lifetime of service to the United States as a member of the United States Marine Corps Reserve from 1957 to 1963; and

WHEREAS, upon graduation from law school, he joined the Nashville legal firm of Goodpasture, Carpenter, Woods and Sasser, where he remained a partner until 1972; and

WHEREAS, having been bitten by the political bug after working on political campaigns early in his career, Senator Sasser served as the Chairman of the Tennessee Democratic Party; and

WHEREAS, in 1976, Jim Sasser was elected to the United States Senate, where he served with distinction for three terms, which included a tenure as chairman of the Committee on the Budget of the Senate that saw him help negotiate and pass budget deals under presidents George H. W. Bush and Bill Clinton; and

WHEREAS, Senator Sasser was universally respected by colleagues on both sides of the aisle for his thoughtful, thorough, and bridge-building approach to legislating that allowed him to pass significant fiscal reform measures and successfully eliminate the federal deficit for the first time in a generation; and

WHEREAS, from 1996 to 1999, Senator Sasser served as the United States Ambassador to China under President Bill Clinton, where he worked to improve relations between the two countries and arranged mutual state visits; and

WHEREAS, after his service as U.S. Ambassador to China, Senator Sasser served as a visiting professor at George Washington University and later as a professor at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill; and

WHEREAS, Senator Sasser was also deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Senator Sasser enjoyed the loving companionship of his wife of sixty years, Mary Gorman Sasser, and was the proud father of James Gray Sasser and Elizabeth Sasser and the doting grandfather of four grandchildren; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his wife, children, and grandchildren, he will be sadly mourned but fondly remembered by his sisters, Jo Marilyn O'Brien and Phyllis Donnally, and a host of dear friends and former colleagues; and

WHEREAS, on November 3, 2024, a celebration and thanksgiving for the life of Senator Sasser was held at Second Presbyterian Church in Nashville, Tennessee, which featured family remembrances by members of his family, including James Gray Sasser, Elizabeth Sasser, Martha Gray Sasser, Ella Parrott, and Mary Hayden Sasser, a reading by Atticus Parrott, a eulogy by historian and author Jon Meacham, and remarks by Vice President Albert Gore, Jr., Senator Christopher John Dodd, and Dr. David Kidd; and

WHEREAS, Senator Jim Sasser leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being, whose contributions to the State of Tennessee stand as a monument to a job well done; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of James Ralph Sasser, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Senator Sasser.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.